

GOWDA'S FLIP FLOPS

A notorious history of treachery and back stabbings

Congressman Dharam Singh was Gowda's choice as chief minister which he clinched during talks with Sonia Gandhi. But Gowda did not flinch when his son H.D. Kumaraswamy toppled Singh's government to bed the BJP. Reason: Kumaraswamy would be chief minister.

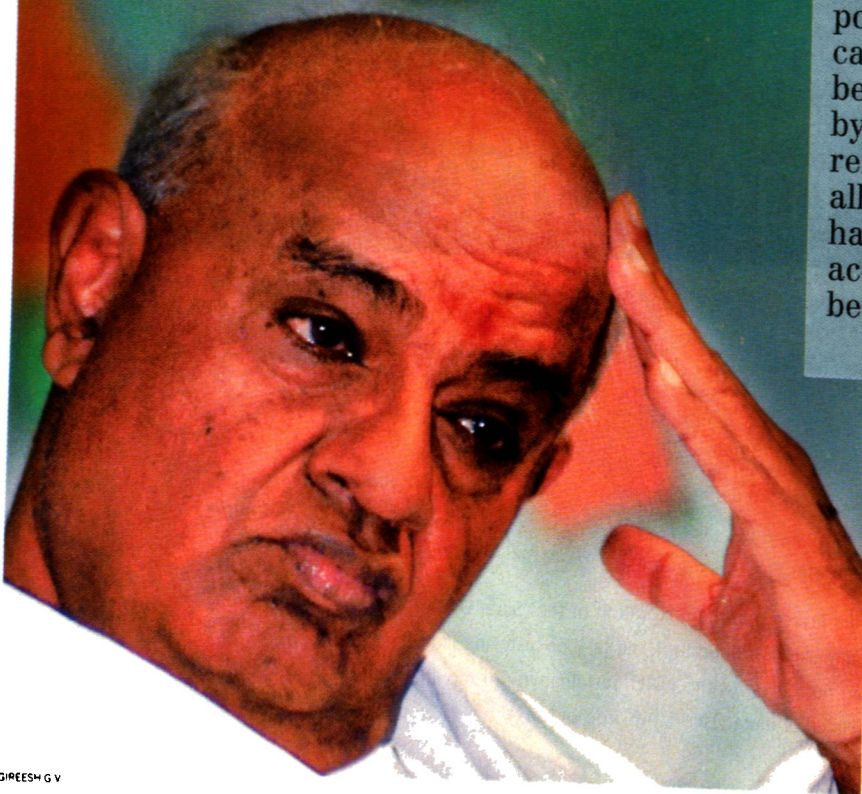
Congress leader M.V. Rajashekharan was Gowda's choice for chief minister as the former represents the state's biggest community—the Lingayats. The idea was to appease the Lingayats just in case he broke links with BJP or with Yeddyurappa. Though JD(S) Lingayat leader M.P. Prakash was sent to Delhi for this, but Gowda just closed the lid.

Siddaramaiah, deputy chief minister under Dharam Singh, was promised the top post initially. Even Sharad Pawar and Sharad Yadav wanted Siddaramaiah as chief minister. When Gowda became too focused on his "kitchen cabinet", his family, Siddaramaiah left Gowda.

Gowda's erstwhile man Friday—Chand Mahal Ibrahim—and the only key Muslim patriarch in the JD(S) fell out because Gowda ditched him for the Rajya Sabha to help industrialist M.A.M. Ramaswamy. Ibrahim dumped the Gowdas and is now awaiting formal entry to the Congress.

Ramakrishna Hegde helped Gowda during his lean days, but the first step he took as prime minister was to throw Hegde out of the party.

Gowda as prime minister was at his interfering best during J.H. Patel's chief ministership, when he flew to Karnataka at least 20 times between June 1996 to April 1997.



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himself or his own family members," Shivakumar says. "He is very spiteful, and does not forget or forgive easily. He has a soft exterior but a very cunning mind inside," he adds. He is so suspicious of Gowda that he sees the former prime minister's role even in the Delimitation Commission's decision to merge his constituency with a neighbouring one, leaving him with no seat to contest elections from next year. "I know who is behind this", he adds.

According to Siddaramaiah, a former Gowda aide and JD(S) deputy chief minister under Dharam Singh, who ditched his one-time mentor to join the Congress, Gowda is the kind who will embrace you without you realising that the hand that's hugging you also holds a knife. Once, Gowda had publicly announced that Siddaramaiah, a Kuruba community leader from the old Mysore district in southern Karnataka, would one day become the chief minister. But when he saw Siddaramaiah emerging as a leader in his own right, he was quick to spot a threat to the political careers of his sons. "You either blindly follow him or you leave him, there is nothing in between," says a chastened

Gowda's political career has been marked by multiple relationships all of which have ended in accusations of betrayal.

Siddaramaiah, who was instrumental in convincing the Congress not to enter into an alliance of convenience with JD(S) after the BJP government fell. "Since his interests are not beyond those of his family it is clear where his priorities are. If you show dissent or reveal you can think, be sure

you will be out of his sight."

Betraying friends and ditching allies is not new to Gowda. Former Karnataka chief minister Ramakrishna Hegde once recalled how he and his team had worked overtime to ensure Gowda's victory in elections to the Lok Sabha from the Kanakapura constituency. Among the first things that Gowda did as prime minister in 1996 was to throw out Hegde—one of the founder members of the Janata Party. Gowda also had a